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2023CS10941

Subject - HUL 272

## VILLAGE STUDIES.

British colonialists viewed India as a land defined by :-

- 1) caste system
- 2) "village republics"

### village republics

This concept in colonial period suggested that Indian villages were self-sufficient, independent units with their own form of local governance.

- The idea of "village" republics" was criticized by many Indian thinkers and authors, who argued that the concept was misrepresented the reality of rural India.
- Some of the renowned scholars include M.N. Srinivas and A.M. Shah who critiqued the colonial interpretation of Indian villages.
- M.N. Srinivas taught Postgraduate (PG) Sociology and was a distinguished professor at the DELHI SCHOOL OF ~~E~~ ECONOMICS.



## Early views about villages ~~republics~~ in India

### ① Sir Thomas Munro's report (1812)

- internal organization remains unchanged regardless of political events.
- 'little republics' (Charles Metcalfe's view eg)
- Political and economic self-sufficiency

### ② Karl Marx (also Henry Maine)

- village viewed as a community
- Unchanging
- No individual ownership of land in villages
- Strict division on the basis of caste
- Famous words of Karl Marx: —  
"structure of the economic elements of society remain untouched by the storm clouds in the political sky".

### ③ Charles Metcalfe

Metcalfe believed that Indian villages was an ancient and self-sustaining institution.

He viewed the village as an



autonomous unit, with its own customs, administration, and local governance.

#### ④ Mahatma Gandhi

Gandhi argued that villages should be economically and politically self-sufficient. He proposed that economic self-sufficiency also comes with "caste" divisions / has a "caste" component in it.

#### Village solidarity

a profoundly used term with "village republic". Village solidarity refers to the social cohesion and unity that exists in a village community where individuals come together through shared social, cultural, or economic ties.

#### 2 concepts of village solidarity

##### ① Architectural unity

refers to cohesion / unity among residents ~~inside~~ confined to a certain village ~~which~~ <sup>is</sup> inside the boundary built around the village.



# Sociological unity



Just like the existence of independent villages, ~~vill~~ a single village could be divided into ~~2~~ different clusters/hamlets based on caste.

- within these hamlets, people may have unity among themselves for belonging to a particular division.

- However, inter-cluster unity / interaction might be limited. eg - low caste clusters might be severely isolated from that of the upper class, they may not celebrate festivals together etc.

(with AM Shah)  
M.N. Srinivas, in his book "The

India village - Myth & reality" opposed the colonial view of villages stating that "village republic" as a concept was flawed ~~because of~~ based on some arguments below -

- ① Villages were not self-sufficient but deeply connected to wider markets, towns and cities. Villages were interdependent on each other for economic exchanges eg - selling crops grown in one



village to another, buying and selling animals, participate in village fairs, pottery, selling ~~to~~ utensils etc.

### Marriage

- ② Marriage ties between a caste group of a village to a family of the same caste division, but belonging to a different village as a whole showed how marriage, migration etc. often tied village to large social networks.

~~He says~~ They argued that the dynamic village system was not captured by the British

### Some concepts

- Endogamy - "gamy" - marriage  
"Endo" - within  
stands for marriage within a group (type of group not specified)  
eg - caste endogamy (marriage within the same caste).
  - Exogamy - marriage outside a group.
  - Hypergamy - a woman marrying into a social class/caste higher than her's own.
- Hence, after marriage<sup>E</sup>, women are moved up in the caste hierarchy.



This follows because Marriages was also about political relations.  
Hence, marrying a women from other caste may help the groom side to take over territories of people from different social divisions of society.

- Agnatic group - group of individuals belonging to the same ancestral lineage from the male side.
- Vertical solidarity - sense of unity among ~~and~~ people across different levels of hierarchy / social class.  
eg - caste solidarity - unity among people of different caste castes.
- Horizontal solidarity - equality / cooperation among individuals at the same level of social, economic or political hierarchy.
- Dominant caste - caste which is dominant socially, politically, numerically, economically.  
however, The dominant caste need not belong to the highest verns.